

University of Zagreb
Faculty of Croatian Studies

Philosophy of Politics:
Communism: philosophical roots and Marx'
critique of capitalism

Sandro Scansi

Communism: Philosophical Roots and Marx's Critique of Capitalism

- Philosophical origins of Marxism
- Historical materialism and class struggle
- Marx's analysis of capitalism
- Alienation, exploitation and ideology
- Central question: *Why does Marx believe capitalism creates the conditions for its own transformation?*

What Is Communism?

- Communism predates Marx as an idea and political aspiration
- Marx and Engels transform it into a theory of historical and social change
- Private ownership of the means of production becomes a central object of critique
- The ultimate horizon is a classless society
- Marx provides relatively little detailed institutional blueprint for communist society

Before Marx

- Communal ownership and egalitarian ideas have long intellectual histories
- The French Revolution radicalized debates about equality and property
- Early nineteenth-century socialism criticized industrial capitalism
- Marx inherited these debates but rejected purely moral or utopian criticism
- His ambition was to explain ***how societies actually develop and change***

Three Philosophical Roots

- German philosophy: Hegel and Feuerbach
- British political economy: Smith and Ricardo
- French socialism and revolutionary politics
- Marx combines philosophy, economics and political analysis
- The result is a theory of capitalism as a historically specific social system

Hegel: History and Contradiction

- Hegel understands social institutions historically
- Political and social forms develop rather than remaining fixed
- Contradictions play an important role in historical transformation
- Freedom itself has a historical dimension
- Marx inherits the historical orientation while rejecting Hegel's philosophical idealism

From Hegel to Marx

- Hegel gives priority to the development of consciousness and ideas
- Marx increasingly emphasizes material social relations
- Human beings transform the world through practical activity
- Production becomes fundamental to understanding social organization
- Marx's critique therefore turns philosophy toward material and economic life

Feuerbach and Alienation

- Ludwig Feuerbach interprets religion as a human creation
- Human qualities are projected onto an external divine being
- Human beings then become subordinate to their own creation
- Marx adopts the concept of alienation
- But he shifts the analysis from religion toward material and social relations

Marx's Critique of Feuerbach

- Religious criticism alone is insufficient
- Ideas cannot be understood independently of material conditions
- Alienated consciousness reflects alienated social relations
- Changing beliefs therefore does not necessarily change society
- *The world must be transformed, not merely interpreted differently*

Political Economy

- Marx studies Adam Smith, David Ricardo and classical economics
- Labor, value, wages, profit and accumulation become central categories
- Marx accepts capitalism's extraordinary productive capacity
- But he rejects the assumption that capitalist relations are natural or permanent
- Political economy becomes an object of historical critique

Marx's Method

- Begin with historically specific social relations
- Examine how production is organized
- Identify the classes generated by that organization
- Analyze conflicts and contradictions within the system
- Capitalism is therefore studied as a ***historical mode of production***

Historical Materialism

- Human beings must produce the means of their existence
- Production requires social cooperation
- Different forms of production generate different social relations
- Political and intellectual life cannot be understood independently of these material relations
- History must therefore be analyzed from the organization of social production

Forces and Relations of Production

- **Productive forces:** labor, skills, technology and productive resources
- **Relations of production:** social relations governing production and control
- Different combinations constitute different modes of production
- Relations that once facilitated production can become obstacles to further development
- Such tensions can contribute to historical transformation

Modes of Production

- Ancient societies
- Feudalism
- Capitalism
- Different modes of production generate different class structures
- Capitalism is therefore neither natural nor historically eternal
- It is one stage within a broader historical development

Class Struggle

- Social classes occupy different positions within systems of production
- Their interests can therefore conflict
- Marx and Engels make class struggle central to their interpretation of recorded history
- Political conflict is connected to underlying social relations
- Class is therefore both an economic and political category

The Revolutionary Bourgeoisie

- Marx does not portray the bourgeoisie as historically passive
- It undermines feudal social relations
- It expands markets and productive forces
- It transforms technology, communication and social organization
- Capitalism is simultaneously ***historically revolutionary and internally conflictual***

Capitalism as a Mode of Production

- Private ownership of the means of production
- Production primarily for market exchange
- Wage labor
- Competition and capital accumulation
- Generalization of commodity relations
- These institutions form an interconnected social system

Bourgeoisie and Proletariat

- **Bourgeoisie:** owners of the means of production
- **Proletariat:** workers who lack independent access to productive resources
- Workers therefore sell their labor power
- The relationship is legally contractual
- Marx asks what social structure lies behind this formally free exchange

Capitalism and Formal Freedom

- Capitalist workers are not legally owned by employers
- They formally enter contracts as free persons
- Liberal legal equality therefore represents a genuine historical transformation
- But workers must obtain their means of subsistence
- Marx distinguishes ***formal freedom from material relations of dependence***

The Commodity

- Capitalist production increasingly takes the form of commodity production
- Goods are produced primarily for exchange
- Labor power itself becomes a commodity
- Social relations are increasingly mediated through markets
- Marx's later critique of capitalism begins from analysis of this commodity form

Labor Power

- Workers do not simply sell completed products
- They sell their capacity to work for a period of time
- The capitalist purchases this labor power
- Production can generate value exceeding the cost of labor power
- This distinction becomes central to Marx's theory of exploitation

Surplus Value

- Workers create value through productive activity
- Wages do not represent the total value produced
- The difference contributes to surplus value
- Surplus value becomes the basis for profit and accumulation in Marx's analysis
- Exploitation is therefore understood structurally, not simply as unusually low wages

Exploitation

- Exploitation does not require an individual capitalist to be personally malicious
- Capitalists themselves operate under competitive pressures
- Firms must remain profitable and accumulate capital
- Marx's critique therefore targets a ***social relation***
- The problem is systemic rather than reducible to individual morality

Capital Accumulation

- Capital is invested to generate additional capital
- Competition encourages continual reinvestment
- Firms seek greater productivity and lower costs
- Technological transformation becomes structurally encouraged
- Capitalism therefore contains a powerful dynamic of continual expansion

Competition and Innovation

- Competition pressures producers to innovate
- Productivity rises
- Existing industries are continually transformed
- Older economic relations are disrupted
- Marx recognizes capitalism's unprecedented productive dynamism
- His critique is therefore not a simple rejection of technological progress

Marx's Theory of Alienation

- Alienation describes problematic separation within human social life
- Capitalist labor separates workers from important dimensions of productive activity
- Alienation is especially prominent in Marx's early writings
- It connects economic organization with human flourishing
- The critique asks what kind of human activity work could become

Four Dimensions of Alienated Labor

- Alienation from the **product** of labor
- Alienation from the **activity** of labor
- Alienation from **other human beings**
- Alienation from one's **human capacities or species-being**
- Work becomes something experienced as external rather than self-realizing

Alienation from the Product

- Workers create objects they do not own or control
- The product belongs to the employer
- The worker's productive activity confronts them as someone else's property
- Human creation acquires an apparently independent power

We produce a world that can come to dominate us

Alienation from Work

- Work becomes primarily a means to obtain wages
- Productive activity is directed by external requirements
- Workers often lack control over what and how they produce
- Labor can therefore become external to self-realization
- Marx contrasts alienated labor with freely directed productive activity

Alienation from Others and Self

- Market relations can encourage individuals to encounter one another instrumentally
- Workers compete with other workers
- Capital and labor confront one another through conflicting structural interests
- Human creative capacities are subordinated to economic necessity
- Alienation is therefore simultaneously economic and social

Commodity Fetishism

- Commodities appear to possess value independently of human social relations
- Relations among people appear as relations among things
- Market outcomes can appear natural and impersonal
- Human-created institutions confront their creators as external forces
- Capitalist social relations can therefore become difficult to recognize as social relations

Ideology

- Marx's treatment of ideology develops across different writings
- Dominant ideas cannot be understood independently of social relations
- Existing institutions can appear natural, universal or inevitable
- Historically specific arrangements may therefore escape critical scrutiny
- Ideological critique asks:

Which social relations are concealed by apparently neutral ideas?

Marx's Critique of Liberal Rights

- Liberal rights protect important forms of political emancipation
- But legal equality does not eliminate economic class relations
- Formally equal citizens can possess radically unequal economic power
- Marx therefore distinguishes political emancipation from broader human emancipation
- His critique seeks to move from juridical equality toward transformation of social relations

Marx and the State

- Marx rejects the idea that political institutions can always be understood independently of class relations
- Economic and political power are interconnected
- Formal political equality can coexist with economic domination
- Changing government alone may therefore leave fundamental social relations intact
- Political transformation requires attention to the structure of production

Contradictions of Capitalism

- Capitalism develops productive forces on an enormous scale
- Production becomes increasingly social and interdependent
- Ownership remains concentrated in private hands
- Capital and labor retain conflicting structural interests
- Marx sees these tensions as sources of potential systemic transformation

The Proletariat as Revolutionary Class

- Capitalism concentrates workers within common productive structures
- Workers share a structural relationship to capital
- Class position can generate common political interests
- Marx and Engels expect the proletariat to become an agent of social transformation
- Economic class must therefore become ***political class consciousness***

Revolution

- Marx does not understand communism primarily as an ethical blueprint imposed upon society
- It is connected to contradictions generated within existing social relations
- Capitalism creates productive capacities that make different arrangements conceivable
- Class struggle provides an agent of transformation
- Revolution aims at transforming the structure of property and production

What Would Communism Abolish?

- Capitalist private ownership of the means of production
- Class domination based on ownership
- Wage labor as a structurally dominant social relation
- Systematic exploitation associated with class society
- Ultimately, the division between antagonistic economic classes

What Marx Leaves Unspecified

- Marx offers relatively little detailed institutional design for mature communist society
- How exactly would economic coordination operate?
- What political institutions would remain?
- How would collective decisions be made?
- How would disagreement and conflicting interests be managed?
- These unresolved questions become central to later communist theory and practice

Marx's Critique of Capitalism

- **Exploitation:** appropriation of surplus within the wage-labor relation
- **Alienation:** loss of control over productive and social activity
- **Class domination:** unequal structural positions within production
- **Ideology:** historically specific relations can appear natural or universal
- **Contradiction:** capitalism produces forces and conflicts that can challenge its own social structure

The Marxian Question

- Hegel: *How does contradiction generate historical transformation?*
- Feuerbach: *How can human creations become alien powers?*
- Marx: *How do material social relations structure political life?*
- **The Communist Manifesto:** *How does capitalism produce both extraordinary development and class conflict?*
- Central question for the next lecture: *If capitalism can be transformed, how could a complex society actually be organized after it?*